



YOU ARE **32 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

54 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

During this week your baby's fingernails have become fully developed and now approach the tips of the fingers. Bathed in amniotic fluid, the nails are kept very soft: it's only after birth that your baby might tend to scratch and need to wear mittens.

“Every 40 minutes, your baby swallows enough amniotic fluid to fill their stomach, before emptying it back into the amniotic sac.”

Your baby is swallowing and recycling almost half a liter (18 fl oz) of amniotic fluid each day. In addition to providing nutrients, especially proteins, this fluid is important for the healthy development of the gut. Your baby's sense of taste is thought to have developed to such an extent now that if you have eaten spiced food it can be distinguished in the amniotic fluid they drink.

Amniotic fluid does not enter the lungs but travels down the esophagus into the stomach where it is stored for a short time. At this stage, the stomach fills every 40 minutes, but, from 35 weeks, as the stomach enlarges, this rate slows down to every 80 minutes. Muscle contractions move the fluid in waves into the small and then large bowel. As it travels along the bowel, water is reabsorbed so that only waste material, or “meconium,” enters the colon, the final section of the large bowel. This meconium accumulates in the large bowel, which is completely full by the time your baby is born. Babies don't usually pass meconium before the birth but do so soon after. Meconium consists mainly of skin cells, lanugo hairs, and vernix. It has a greenish color due to the presence of bilirubin, a breakdown product from red blood cells.

FALSE ALARMS

In the next few weeks, as you and your partner await your baby's arrival, you may experience one or two false alarms, especially if it's your first baby. A false alarm can come at any time of the day or night and it won't respect important meetings or deadlines.

It can help if you—as well as your partner—familiarize yourself with all the signs that indicate labor may be starting (see [Approaching labor](#)). If, however, you're ever in doubt, contact your doctor to ascertain that labor has not started, instead of assuming that this is the case. She will be very experienced in dealing with false alarms and won't mind you contacting her.

ITCHY SKIN

Having itchy skin on your belly is common. As the skin there stretches and thins, it can become dry. If, however, you have severe itching on your abdomen, or on the palms of your hands or soles